



Intel's smartphone foray

Intel announced plans to expand its smartphone lineup via partnerships with carriers and manufacturers. <http://dgit.in/GJEx7>

Hot Windows 8

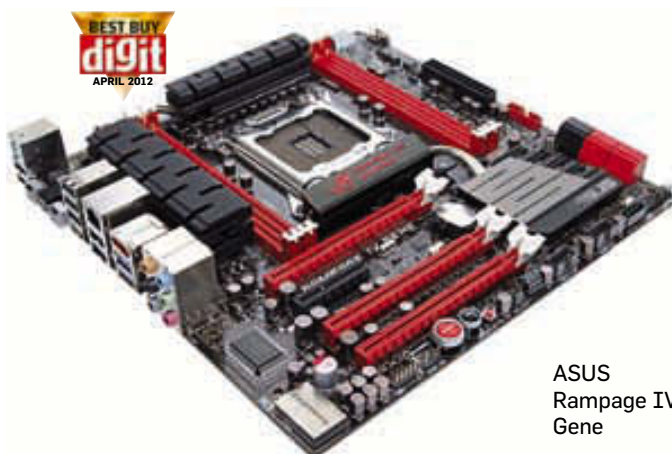
Microsoft announced Windows 8 Consumer Preview had already been downloaded over a 1 million times, in the first 24 hours. <http://dgit.in/GGC8EV>

have voltage checking points. You also have a dedicated fan control utility.

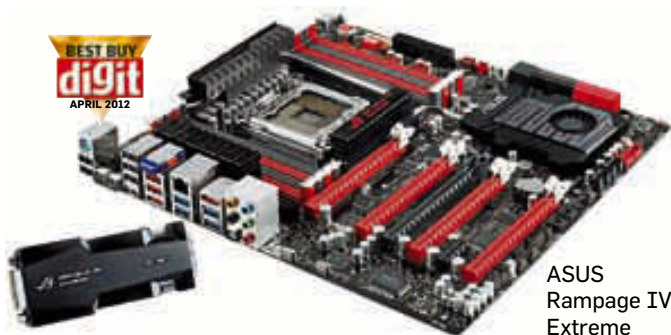
ASUS was the only brand which had neatly categorised line-up of boards and we also got around six boards from them. Some features seen on ASUS boards include ASUS's proprietary SSD caching application – X79 chipset does not support SSD caching natively; BIOS flashback; Thermal Radar – which is a utility to monitor on-board temperatures and voltages and also control fan speeds. The UEFI BIOS is as impressive and easy to navigate as ever. But one implementation that we absolutely loved was

Moving on, we have the P9X79 series of boards namely P9X79 PRO and P9X79 Deluxe. Both the boards look identical, but the Deluxe sports an onboard WiFi and Bluetooth adapter, which can be attached between the Gigabit LAN port and the USB port tower on the top end of the back IO panel.

Republic of Gamers series board from ASUS are packed to the gills with features. We have seen these features evolve over the years. The X79 chipset sporting ROG boards are a different kind of beast though. The Rampage IV Extreme which is the flagship board in this line, is an enthusiast's dream. Fea-



ASUS
Rampage IV
Gene



ASUS
Rampage IV
Extreme

the option to use shortcut keys when in the BIOS, to quickly pull up a list of commonly opened menus. Just hit F3 from anywhere in the BIOS and you will get a list of options to choose from, thus easing navigation.

The ASUS Sabertooth X79 board belongs to the TUF series of boards promising a whopping 5 year warranty which is the maximum offered by any board we tested. The green and brown design is carried forward but one noticeable difference is the heatsink design. Both the heatsinks have an active-cooling mechanism (the fan on the VRM heatsink is optional) with the fans blowing the air out of the motherboard. You will not find a dedicated power reset or over-clocking button on the board.

tures such as ROG Connect, Extreme Engine Digi+II, load-line calibration, voltage check points on-board are present on all ROG boards. It also comes with the X-socket which allows you to use a Socket LGA1366 cooler on Socket 2011. The USB BIOS flash option allows you to save or update BIOS via a simple button push requiring only the motherboard to be powered on.

The Rampage IV Extreme, offers exclusive features such as: sub-zero sense – which allows liquid nitrogen (LN2) enthusiasts to note sub zero temperatures upto -195.8 degrees Celcius via a subzero sense connector using a K-type thermocouple cable which has extreme temperature tolerance – thereby saving your money on expen-

sive digital thermometers; OC Key – this is the piece-de-resistance connector which gives a graphical overlay on your display allowing you to monitor or make tweaks to settings such as clock speeds, voltages, DRAM settings – in real time; VGA Hotwire – allows enthusiasts indulging in GPU overvolting to regulate the voltage from the board's pin connectors.

Apart from this, you have dedicated power, reset buttons and PCIe switches on Extreme and Formula boards. The Rampage IV Formula is a relatively economical version of the Extreme and does not have subzero sense, VGA hotwire or OC Key.

The Rampage IV Gene offers a great ROG feature set and is ideal for those who want the ROG features but are on a budget. It comes in a micro-ATX form factor though and four DIMM slots.

Build quality of all three boards is very good. Heatsinks on all the three Rampage boards are top notch, with the Extreme board having an active fan cooler on the Southbridge.

BIOS and Overclocking

The UEFI BIOS of the MSI boards is very well laid out and has a home page which quickly allows you to select specific options instead of going through all the menus. The OC Genie II button helps in easy over-clocking on the fly. We could overclock the Big Bang board to 4.5 GHz over the air whereas the GD45 could be stretched upto 4.4 GHz.

One of the most interesting change in Gigabyte boards seen with this chipset is the introduction of UEFI BIOS (finally!). Gigabyte calls it '3D



Gigabyte
X79-UD5